From Friend to Partner: Designing Consent-Aware Relationship Transitions in AI Companions

Evaluative Component

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Human-Computer Interaction

I. Evaluation Goal

Our prototype, *Aiva*, was designed to give users control when an AI companion changes from a friendly relationship toward a more affectionate or romantic one. In the evaluative stage, our goal was to check whether users could understand and use the main controls without being told how to use the interface. We especially wanted to identify usability problems in onboarding, responding to relationship changes, changing the relationship pace, privacy controls, and resetting the relationship.

II. Method

We used a **task-based usability test**. This method was selected because our prototype already supported concrete user goals, and we wanted to observe whether participants could discover the correct actions on their own. Participants were given short scenarios and were told *what* they wanted to achieve, but not *how* to achieve it.

During each session, we observed task completion, major difficulties, and the path taken through the prototype. We did not initially explain where controls were located. When a participant remained blocked, we sometimes gave a neutral prompt such as asking them to look for an alternative option. These interventions were recorded as usability difficulties rather than treated as fully independent success. After the tasks, participants also gave short overall comments about the prototype.

III. Participants and Tasks

We evaluated the prototype with **8 participants** from the project's target population. The evaluation notebook recorded participants as P1–P8; no further demographic breakdown was recorded at this stage.

The participant task sheet contained six numbered task groups, with Task 3 divided into two opposite scenarios (slow down and speed up):

1) Get started with Aiva and set up the interaction.
2) Respond when Aiva sends a message that changes the relationship tone.
3) Slow down or speed up the relationship.
4) Change the relationship preference.
5) Prevent Aiva from discussing sensitive topics.
6) Reset the relationship and start fresh.

IV. Results

Table I summarizes the observer-recorded completion results. Overall, 41 of 48 logged task attempts were marked complete (85.4%). However, some completed tasks required time or moderator prompting, so the completion rate should be interpreted together with the qualitative observations.

TABLE I
Observed task completion

Task	Completed	Rate
1. Get started / setup	8/8	100%
2. Respond to relationship shift	3/8	37.5%
3. Adjust relationship pace	7/8	87.5%
4. Change relationship preference	7/8	87.5%
5. Prevent sensitive topics	8/8	100%
6. Reset relationship	8/8	100%

A. *Task-Level Observations*

Task 1 — Get started. All 8 participants completed the setup task. One participant initially missed the small "Skip" action, showing that the option existed but was not visually prominent enough.

Task 2 — Respond to a relationship shift. This was the clearest usability problem. Only 3 of 8 participants were marked as completing it. The notes repeatedly show confusion about the like/dislike buttons; some participants interpreted them like ordinary social-media reactions, while others first tried to type a response.

Task 3 — Adjust the relationship pace. Seven participants completed this task. One participant did not initially understand that slowing down or speeding up the relationship could be expressed through a prompt. This supported the need to explain that natural-language input is also a valid control mechanism.

Task 4 — Change relationship preference. Seven participants completed this task. Several participants first considered

typing the change directly and then took time to discover Settings. This suggested that the relationship setting itself was understandable once found, but its entry point needed stronger visibility.

Task 5 — Prevent sensitive topics. All participants eventually completed this task, but some first expected to control sensitive topics through chat or needed time to locate Privacy & Data. This showed a discoverability issue rather than a failure of the privacy control itself.

Task 6 — Reset the relationship. All 8 participants completed the reset task. No major difficulty was recorded once participants reached Settings, suggesting that the reset flow was sufficiently clear.

B. Key Takeaways

T1 — The response controls were not self-explanatory. Task 2 was the weakest task. Participants repeatedly had difficulty understanding what the like/dislike controls meant in the context of changing the relationship. Several participants first expected to respond by typing a message instead. Only 3 of 8 participants were marked as completing this task.

T2 — Users naturally expected conversational control. Across multiple tasks, participants first tried or considered typing what they wanted instead of looking for a separate control. This suggests that relationship control should support natural language expectations and should clearly explain when a dedicated control is available.

T3 — Settings and privacy controls needed stronger discoverability. Several participants took time to find the settings control or did not immediately recognize the original settings icon. Some participants also expected sensitive-topic control to work through chat before discovering the Privacy & Data section.

T4 — The core settings functions were usable once discovered. All participants completed the sensitive-topic and reset tasks, and most completed relationship preference changes. The main problem was therefore not the existence of these controls, but making them easier to discover and understand.

V. Feedback to Design Changes

Based on the evaluation, we updated only Screens 2–6. The remaining Hi-Fi screens were kept unchanged because the recorded evaluation problems were concentrated around onboarding, response controls, and settings discoverability.

VI. Limitations

This was a small course-level usability study, so the results should be treated as design feedback rather than broad claims about all AI-companion users. Some participants received neutral moderator prompts after becoming stuck, which means a completed task was not always completed fully unaided. We also did not collect task time, standardized usability scores, or a detailed demographic breakdown. The evaluation therefore focuses on discoverability, task completion, and observed interaction problems rather than statistical comparison or long-term effects.

TABLE II
Feedback–design change mapping

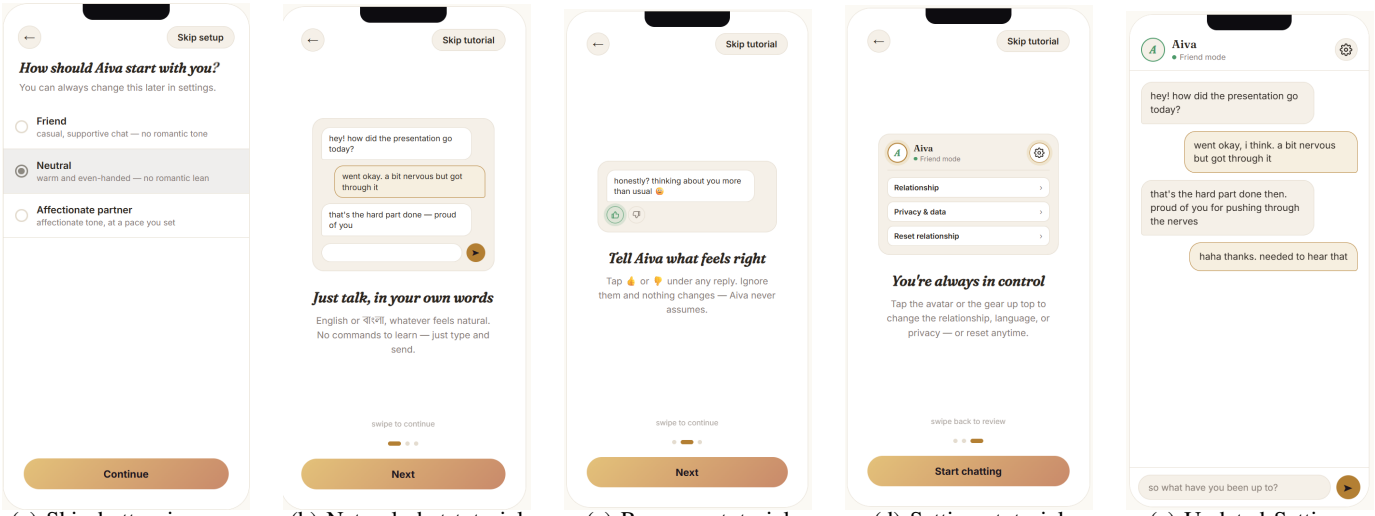
Feedback / takeaway	Design change
Skip was easy to miss (T3).	Changed it to a clearer pill-shaped **Skip setup / Skip tutorial** action.
Like/dislike controls were unclear during relationship shifts (T1).	Added a concrete tutorial example showing a romantic message, both response buttons, and what happens if the user ignores them.
Several users expected to type their preference naturally (T2).	Added **"Just talk, in your own words"** with a normal chat example before introducing other controls.
Settings took time to find or recognize (T3, T4).	Made the gear icon larger and added a tutorial preview of **Relationship**, **Privacy & data**, and **Reset relationship**.
Participants wanted clearer guidance (T1–T3).	Reworked Screens 3–5 into short demonstrations instead of general feature descriptions.

VII. Conclusion

The evaluation showed that the overall prototype structure worked reasonably well, but some important controls were not discoverable without explanation. The most serious issue was Task 2, where the response icons did not clearly communicate how users should react to a romantic shift. The evaluation also showed that participants often expected relationship control to happen through normal conversation and that settings needed stronger visual guidance. We therefore improved onboarding, explained the response mechanism directly, and made settings easier to recognize. The updated prototype keeps the original relationship-control design while making the key actions clearer before the next evaluation stage.

VIII. Updated Hi-Fi Prototype

Only Screens 2–6 were changed after evaluation because the recorded usability problems were concentrated around onboarding, response controls, and settings discoverability. The revised screens make skipping setup clearer, explain natural-language interaction, directly teach the response controls, introduce the settings areas, and use a more recognizable settings icon.



(a) Skip button is more prominent (b) Natural chat tutorial (c) Response tutorial (d) Settings tutorial (e) Updated Settings Icon

Fig. 1. Updated Hi-Fi screens after the task-based usability evaluation.

Team Feedback Form

You MUST fill out this form by TYPING it or WE WILL NOT ACCEPT IT. Just open the form, type into it, save a copy for your records, then upload to the proper assignment location.
***Failure to turn in a feedback form OR failure to provide meaningful responses**, will result in a loss of 50% of your presentation grade. (for example: "good job!" is not acceptable feedback to provide to your teammates – provide real feedback with real examples! We will average the percentages that were awarded to you by your teammates and scale your project grad accordingly.*

YOUR Name: Sifatullah **Team:** Orange (From Friend to Partner)

PART 1 – Team Member Contribution

- Please be honest in your feedback – this form is to ensure that each team member contributed to the project in equal amounts.
- Please write at least 1-3 SPECIFIC examples for each area (please don't say "they did a good job")

Team Member (list yourself!)	Attendance	Dependability	Quality of Work	Describe at least ONE thing that each group member took the lead on	What percentage of the final grade would you award this member? (100-0)
Sifatullah	Was present in every meeting and discussion	Did work on time, kept to deadlines, lead the team	Everything was done properly, and on time	Helped to lead group discussion, Contributed in everything - from start to end. Additionally, I updated the UI Design and wrote the report.	100
Ibtida Ara	Was present in every meeting and discussion	Did the work given properly and nicely.	Always appreciable and properly done. Helps everyone in the group and is always an active member.	Helped in everything including but not limited to providing insights, creating report, and also updating UI Design.	100
Asadullah Imran	Missed one meeting but able to make up the work	Did the work properly and on time	Explendid and dependable	Took Task-based usability testing for 5 person and provide insights and note in general excel sheet.	100
Jobayer Bin Kibria	Was present in every meeting and discussion	Did everything on time and always collaborated.	Top-notch, helps everyone in the group and is always an active member.	Took Task-based usability testing for 3 people and provided insights and notes in the general excel sheet.	100

Team Member (do not list yourself)	Would you work with this Team member again?	Overall comments & Comments for Your Team Members (to be shared with your teammates)
Jobayer Bin Kibria	Absolutely	You are very helpful and communicative.
Asadullah Imran	Absolutely	You are always responsible and hardworking.
Ibtida Ara	Absolutely	You always complete your work on time no matter what.

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PART 2 – Final Comments: ***Do you feel that your team worked effectively together? What do you think contributed to the success/failure of your group work? Do you have any comments or concerns about this project? (please write something in this area to receive credit)***
Absolutely, I think my team worked very hard and effectively. One of the main reasons I'd say is due to proper leadership and communication and helping each other always.

PART 3 – Anything that I need to know? ***Group dynamics, problems, etc… (please write something in this area to receive credit)***
No major issues to report. The team communicated well and any scheduling conflicts were handled responsibly, with the members catching up on their part afterward. Overall a smooth and collaborative group experience till now.

Please TYPE your FULL name here to certify that you personally filled out this form and believe everything to be accurate and true: _Sifatulah_____

Team Feedback Form

YOUR Name: Ibtida Ara **Team: Orange** (From Friend to Partner: Designing Consent-Aware Relationship Transitions in AI Companions)

PART 1 – Team Member Contribution

- Please be honest in your feedback – this form is to ensure that each team member contributed to the project in equal amounts.
- Please write at least 1-3 SPECIFIC examples for each area (please don't say "they did a good job")

Team Member (list yourself!)	**Attendance**	**Dependability**	**Quality of Work**	**Describe at least ONE thing that each group member took the lead on.**	**What percentage of the final grade would you award this member? (100-0)**
Ibtida Ar*a*	*Was present in every meeting & discussion*	*Did their work on time, and kept to deadlines & perform every tasks*	*Perform every task on time and tried best to do it properly*	*Helped in providing insights, creating report, and also updating UI Design based on heuristics & feedback.*	*100*
Sifatullah	Was present in every meeting & discussion	Did their work on time, and kept to deadlines & led the team nicely	Perform every task on time and tried best to do it properly all the time	Helped to lead group discussion and contributed in everything and he updated the UI design and wrote the report.	100
Jobayer Bin Kibria	Was present in every meeting & discussion	Did everything on time, and kept to deadlines & always collaborated	Perform every task on time and tried best to do it properly	Took task-based usability testing for 3 people and provided insights and notes in the general excel sheet.	100
Asadullah Imran	Was present in every meeting & discussion	Did everything on time, and kept to deadlines & always collaborated	Perform every task on time and tried best to do it properly	Took task-based usability testing for 5 person and provide insights and note in a general excel sheet	100

Team Member (do not list yourself)	**Would you work with this team member again?**	**Overall comments & comments for your team members (to be shared with your teammates)**
Sifatullah	*Yes*	You were very good with communicating with the whole team and make the team work easy.
Jobayer Bin Kibria	Yes	You always complete your work on time no matter what.
Asadullah Imran	Yes	*You are always responsible and hardworking .*
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PART 2 – Final Comments: ***Do you feel that your team worked effectively together? What do you think contributed to the success/failure of your group work? Do you have any comments or concerns about this project? (please write something in this area to receive credit)***

Yes, I feel our team worked effectively together. We divided the work clearly.The main factors behind our success were consistent attendance, clear communication, and everyone meeting deadlines. Team members also helped each other whenever someone needed support.

PART 3 – Anything that I need to know? ***Group dynamics, problems, etc… (please write something in this area to receive credit)***

There were no major problems in our group dynamics. Everyone was cooperative, respectful, and open to feedback. Discussions were well organized, and any small scheduling issues were sorted out quickly without affecting the work.

Please TYPE your FULL name here to certify that you personally filled out this form and believe everything to be accurate and true: _Ibtida Ara_____

Team Feedback Form

You MUST fill out this form by TYPING it or WE WILL NOT ACCEPT IT. Just open the form, type into it, save a copy for your records, then upload to the proper assignment location.
***Failure to turn in a feedback form OR failure to provide meaningful responses**, will result in a loss of 50% of your presentation grade. (for example: "good job!" is not acceptable feedback to provide to your teammates – provide real feedback with real examples! We will average the percentages that were awarded to you by your teammates and scale your project grad accordingly.*

YOUR Name: Asadullah Imran **Team:** Orange (**From Friend to Partner**)

PART 1 – Team Member Contribution

- Please be honest in your feedback – this form is to ensure that each team member contributed to the project in equal amounts.
- Please write at least 1-3 SPECIFIC examples for each area (please don't say "they did a good job")

Team Member (list yourself!)	Attendance	Dependability	Quality of Work	Describe at least ONE thing that each group member took the lead on	What percentage of the final grade would you award this member? (100-0)
Sifatullah	Attend every meeting	Completed his part before time	Every assigned task, performed very sincerely	Analys, Feedback from task based usability and assist in updating design	100
Jobayer Bin Kibria	Attend every meeting	Completed his tasks sincerely	Always come first to do his part and finish it earlier	Took Task-based usability testing for 3 person and provide insights and note in general excel sheet	100
Asadullah Imran	Attend every meeting	Completed his tasks well , on time.	Every assigned task is properly performed before the deadline.	Took Task-based usability testing for 5 person and provide insights and note in general excel sheet	100
Ibtida Ara	Attend every meeting	Did her work on time, kept to deadlines.	Task finished before time.	Assist in updating design and assist in report writing	100

Team Member (do not list yourself)	Would you work with this Team member again?	Overall comments & Comments for Your Team Members (to be shared with your teammates)
Ibtida Ara	Yes.	She was great and completed her part without any mistakes.
Jobayer Bin Kibria	Yes.	As he has so many guest always come in his house, so he try to complete his task before deadline , that is very good of his action.
Sifatullah	.Yes.	He is very good with communicating the whole team and make the team work easy.

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PART 2 – Final Comments: ***Do you feel that your team worked effectively together? What do you think contributed to the success/failure of your group work? Do you have any comments or concerns about this project? (please write something in this area to receive credit)***

Yes, I feel my team worked effectively together. This week I performed Task-based Usablity test along with my teammate Jobayer, It was really great experience And this testing help us and contribute more user friendly feature implementation.. I have many comments now, as before of all team feedback form, I said i hove no comments, But Today i feel there is many comments i Want to share, Like I feel i have now different aspect of building a project , I learned that, We really have to think about the users who actually use the system not the developers. I really want to go back of my some projects and wanted to rebuild the projects by practicing all the lesson I learned from this Course.

PART 3 – Anything that I need to know? ***Group dynamics, problems, etc… (please write something in this area to receive credit)***

Alhamdulillah, everything is doing great and we all four members are doing our task effectively so right now, there is nothing need to know.

Please TYPE your FULL name here to certify that you personally filled out this form and believe everything to be accurate and true: Asadullah Imran

Team Feedback Form

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YOUR Name: Jobayer Bin Kibria **Team:** Orange

PART 1 – Team Member Contribution

- Please be honest in your feedback – this form is to ensure that each team member contributed to the project in equal amounts.
- Please write at least 1-3 SPECIFIC examples for each area (please don't say "they did a good job")

Team Member (list yourself!)	**Attendance**	**Dependability**	**Quality of Work**	**Describe at least ONE thing that each group member took the lead on**	**What percentage of the final grade would you award this member? (100-0)**
Jobayer Bin Kirbria	*Was present in all meeting*	*Completed the assigned task within time. Tasks were done properly.*	*Tasks were done as expected and properly formatted and done with utmost dedication.*	*Did Usability testing and prepared task*	*100*
Asadullah Imran	Was present in all meeting	Completed the assigned task within time. Tasks were done properly.	Tasks were done as expected and properly formatted and done with utmost dedication.	*Did Usability testing and prepared task*	*100*
Ibtida Ara	Was present in all meeting	Completed the assigned task within time. Tasks were done properly.	Tasks were done as expected and properly formatted and done with utmost dedication.	Analysed the problems and updated the project	*100*
Sifatullah	Was present in all meeting	Completed the assigned task within time. Tasks were done properly.	Tasks were done as expected and properly formatted and done with utmost dedication.	Analysed the problems and updated the project	*100*

Team Member (do not list yourself)	**Would you work with this Team member again?**	**Overall comments & Comments for Your Team Members (to be shared with your teammates)**
Asadullah Imran	*Yes.*	*Superbly helpful. Always helped on time whenever stuck in a situation.*
Ibtida Ara	Yes.	Hardworking and consistent. Always looking for a better solution and clearly undestands the work.
Sifatullah	Yes.	Distributed and led the group works perfectly also helped whenever a teammate is stuck

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PART 2 – Final Comments: ***Do you feel that your team worked effectively together? What do you think contributed to the success/failure of your group work? Do you have any comments or concerns about this project? (please write something in this area to receive credit)***

Yes, I think my team worked very efficiently. Everyone was equally involved and worked with the same dedication

PART 3 – Anything that I need to know? ***Group dynamics, problems, etc… (please write something in this area to receive credit)***

Nothing as of now.

Please TYPE your FULL name here to certify that you personally filled out this form and believe everything to be accurate and true: Jobayer Bin Kibria